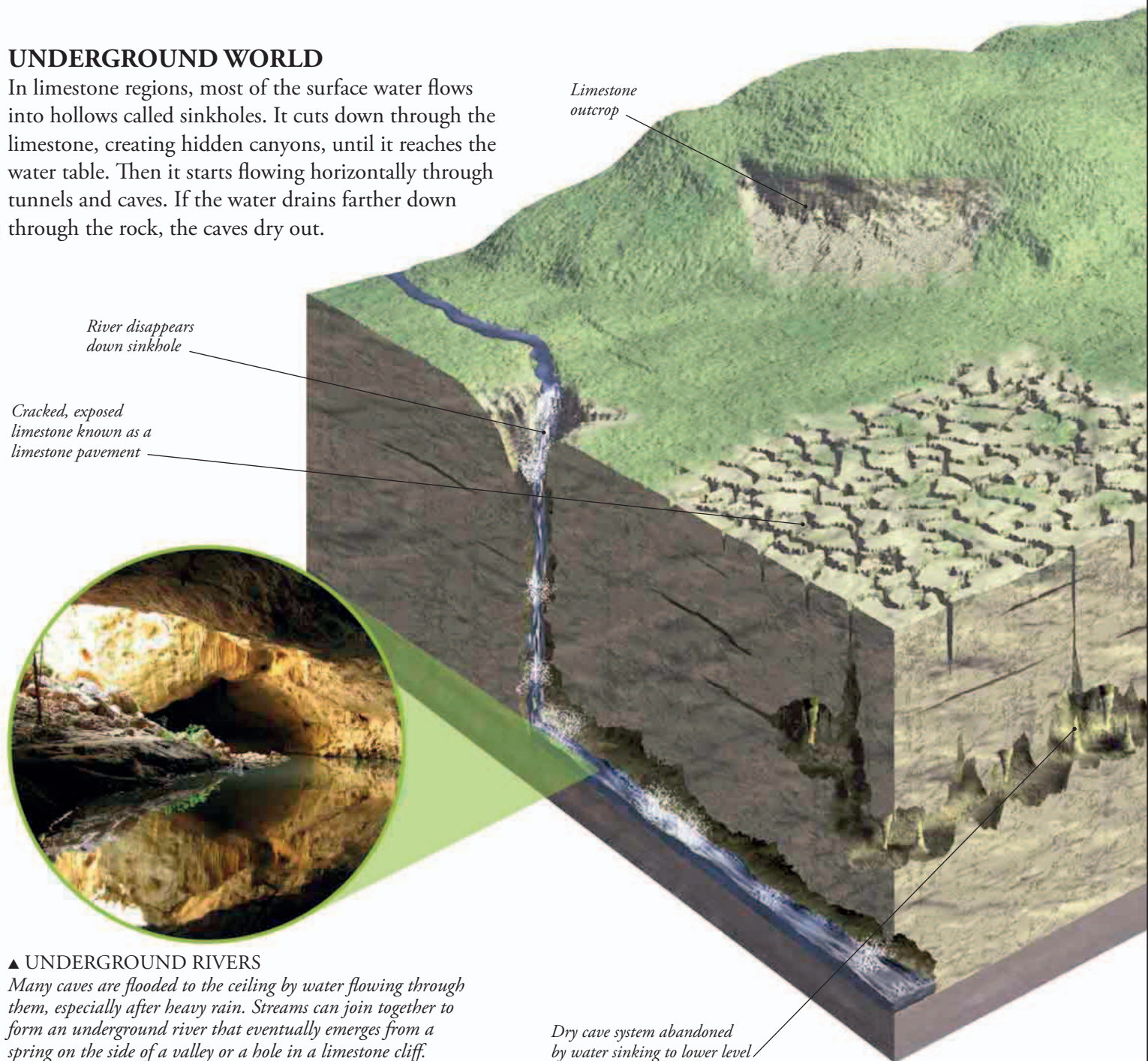


# Caves

Rainwater seeping into the ground in areas with porous limestone can create elaborate networks of caves with spectacular natural rock sculptures. Acid in the water dissolves the rock, seeping into cracks and gradually enlarging them into potholes and caves. Some of these are open to the air, but most are hidden deep underground.

## UNDERGROUND WORLD

In limestone regions, most of the surface water flows into hollows called sinkholes. It cuts down through the limestone, creating hidden canyons, until it reaches the water table. Then it starts flowing horizontally through tunnels and caves. If the water drains farther down through the rock, the caves dry out.



### ▲ UNDERGROUND RIVERS

Many caves are flooded to the ceiling by water flowing through them, especially after heavy rain. Streams can join together to form an underground river that eventually emerges from a spring on the side of a valley or a hole in a limestone cliff.